“WE ARE BEING TARGETED AS WE ARE OPPOSED TO THE POLITICS OF THE BJP GOVERNMENT”



Think of that famous paradox about an irresistible force meeting an immoveable object. Perhaps they met in Kerala chief minister PINARAYI VIJAYAN, 77, because he answers to both descriptions. For one, the state logged 12.1 per cent GSDP in 2021-22, nearly double the national GDP. And for the BJP, long plotting a southern takeover, he is the one monolith that stands in its way. In his second consecutive term now, he may be a bit battle-scarred but the CPI(M)'s stern helmsman is unperturbed. "I don't care for history's verdict, let the people of Kerala judge," he says. Excerpts from an interview with JEEMON JACOB:

Q. You are the only chief minister of Kerala to return to power despite the BJP and Congress consistently trying to undermine you. What is the secret of your success?

A. It is not my personal success but the collective success of the LDF (Left Democratic Front), led by the CPI(M). The people of Kerala know us very well. They know who has stood by them in times of distress and who is trying to place roadblocks in Kerala's development and welfare. They are also quite aware of the political efforts to corner and malign our government. Kerala's success despite all the odds is due to the people's unity and resilience.

Q. Has the gold smuggling through diplomatic channels controversy and the high-voltage media campaign against your government affected your government's credibility?

A. When our government has nothing to do with these matters, how can it affect us? The real question should be why smuggling of contraband articles into the country—through our ports and airports—spiked over the past eight or nine years?

Q. Is interference by central enforcement agencies hampering the performance of your government?

A. They are trying, without much success. We continue to discharge our duties based on our constitutional mandate. We have not abandoned any development initiative or welfare measure, despite the Union trying to arm-twist opposition-ruled states to follow their diktats on relief and welfare measures, development schemes, financial expenditure, borrowings, and so on. As a matter of fact, despite these interferences, Kerala has performed better than the Union, with our GSDP growing at 12.1 per cent as opposed to the national GDP, which is expected to grow at just 6.5 per cent.

Q. Your government was the first to come up with a performance progress card and a 100-day action plan. What was the motivation for it?

A. This is not the first time we have